DEGUANG LI

PhD Researcher in History | Newnham College, University of Cambridge
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RESEARCH PROFILE

I am a third-year PhD researcher in History at the University of Cambridge and a cultural historian of knowledge and science, interested in how societies make sense of the natural world through historically situated practices of observation, communication, and representation. My research focuses on eighteenth- and nineteenth-century Europe, particularly Britain and France, and explores how knowledge was produced, circulated, contested, and transformed across social, institutional, and geographical settings. Taking the Great Comet of 1811 as a microhistorical lens, my doctoral project examines the scientific, cultural, commercial, and political practices through which knowledge of the heavens was constructed in London and Paris. My training in intellectual history and comparative literature informs an interdisciplinary approach to the relationships between knowledge, society, and politics.

EDUCATION

2024–present
PhD in History · University of Cambridge, Newnham College
Dissertation: "Re-enchantment of the Comet in Paris and London, 1811–1812"
Expected submission: June 2027
Current supervisor: Professor Alexandra Walsham
Supervisor (continuing): Professor Emma Spary
Advisor: Dr Joshua Nall

2021–2024
MPhil in Intellectual History · Tsinghua University, Beijing
Thesis: "Theatre in May '68: Antigone as Myth, History, and Ritual." GPA: 4.0/4.0.

Jan–Jun 2020
Exchange studies · Sciences Po, Paris
GPA: 16/20 *(a grade of 16 or higher is considered to be superior work)*

2017–2020
BA in Comparative Literature · Tsinghua University, Beijing
GPA: 3.89/4.0; Tsinghua Xuetang Talents Programme.

PUBLICATIONS AND SCHOLARLY WORK

Accepted / forthcoming

"From Gentleman's Observatory to Women's College: The Transnational Life of the Newnham Telescope" · *Bulletin of the Scientific Instrument Society* · accepted; forthcoming December 2026

Under consideration

"The Making of Superstition: Metropolitan Serial Print and the Ordering of Cometary Knowledge in London, 1811" *under consideration by British Journal for the History of Science*

"A Comet Cannot Become a Sun: Celestial Knowledge and Political Culture in Napoleonic France" *under consideration by French History*

"Retail China: Chineseness, Commodity Knowledge, and the British Trade Card, 1750–1830" *under consideration by Journal for Eighteenth-Century Studies*

Contracted work

"Répétition: Antigone and the Making of Revolutionary Context in Avignon, 1968" · chapter for *Context* (Peter Lang) · under contract; planned 2027

Dominick LaCapra, *History and Criticism* (Cornell University Press, 1985) · Chinese translation by Deguang Li, Commercial Press (商务印书馆) · under contract; manuscript submitted; planned 2027

SELECTED CONFERENCE PAPERS AND TALKS

Sep 2026 — **International Society for Intellectual History (ISIH) Conference, Istanbul**
"(Dis-)Ordering the Heavens, Ordering the Polity: Cometary Knowledge and Political Culture in Napoleonic France."

Jul 2026 — **ESHS/HSS Joint Conference, Edinburgh**
"Re-enchantment: The Making of Cometary Knowledge in London and Paris, 1811–1812."

Mar 2026 — **"Cities" Symposium, University of Cambridge**
"Mapping the Heavens in the City: Cometary Knowledge and Urban Geographies in London and Paris, 1811–1812."

Nov 2025 — **Newnham History Forum, University of Cambridge · keynote**
"Before Newnham: The Transnational Craft, Local Practice, and Women's Scientific Engagement of a Nineteenth-Century Telescope."

Jun 2025 — **Newnham Graduate Conference, University of Cambridge**
"Re-enchantment of the Comet in Paris and London, 1811–1812: On the Uncertainty of Enlightenment."

May 2025 — **IHR British History in the Long Eighteenth Century Seminar**
"Re-enchantment of the Comet in Paris and London, 1811–1812."

Apr 2025 — **Cambridge French Graduate Conference**
"Répétition: Contextualising Antigone in Mai '68."

Mar 2025 — **PhD Presentation Day, University of Cambridge**
"Re-enchantment of the Comet in Paris and London, 1811–1812."

Nov 2024 — **Material Culture Forum, University of Cambridge**
"From Telescopes to Teapots: The Role of Material Culture in Shaping Responses to the Great Comet of 1811."

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE AND METHODS

Archival research across more than twenty repositories in Britain and France, including manuscript, print, visual, and material sources. Experience working with scientific instruments and collections through the Whipple

Museum and the Museum of Archaeology and Anthropology, Cambridge. Digital research methods include structured source databases, historical georeferencing, GIS mapping, and spatial analysis.

ACADEMIC ROLES AND SERVICE

2025–present	**Transcription Project Assistant · Whipple Museum of the History of Science, Cambridge**
2025–present	**Editor · Doing History in Public, University of Cambridge**
2024–present	**Junior Fellow · Institute for World Literatures and Cultures, Tsinghua University**
2023–2024	**Secretariat Assistant · UK–China Humanities Alliance**
2023–2024	**Office Assistant · Institute for World Literatures and Cultures, Tsinghua University**

SELECTED GRANTS AND HONOURS

2026	**Lisa Jardine Grant · Royal Society**
2026	**Conference bursary · Society for the Study of French History**
2026	**Research Support Grant · Royal Historical Society**
2025	**Postgraduate Research & Travel Grants · Newnham College (May and December)**
2025	**Fieldwork Fund · Faculty of History, University of Cambridge**
2025	**Postgraduate Research Grant · Society for the Study of French History**
2022	**Dean’s Scholarship · School of Humanities, Tsinghua University**
2022	**Guang Gu Scholarship (First Class) · Tsinghua University**
2017	**Tsinghua Academy Scholarship for Undergraduates**

LANGUAGES AND AFFILIATIONS

Mandarin Chinese (native); English (fluent); French (working proficiency); Italian (beginner).

Postgraduate member, Royal Historical Society (since 2024); member, British Society for the History of Science (since 2024).